37 bridges, including the cable-stayed Anji Bridge (over Anji river) and the picturesque Chenab Bridge. "The construction in Banihal-Katra corridor involved overcoming geological complexities like fault zones, loose strata and water ingress," says an engineer of the Northern Railways.

In spite of the challenges, the Centre has pushed for the USBRL to establish full connectivity to the Valley as fast as possible. 'It can play an important role in rapid industrialisation, movement of raw materials and finished products from J&K, encourage tourism and provide opportunities for employment,' states the 2021 report of the ministry of railways.

Needless to say, Kashmir's trade bodies eagerly await full rail connectivity. Presently, the Kashmir valley is connected with the rest of India through National Highway 44, but landslides often force it shut for days. Air travel, with high fares on the Srinagar-Delhi route, is unaffordable for most. "The train will attract investment and bring down travel time," says Faiz Ahmad Bakshi, general secretary of Kashmir Chamber of Commerce and Industry. "It will take our horticulture/ agriculture produce like apples to their destinations easily."

The rail link and the development projects announced by Modi are expected to boost the BJP's electoral prospects. Says former deputy chief minister and senior BJP leader Nirmal Singh, "We have done it not on paper, but on the ground, and have been able to reach the completion stage. The train will socially and politically integrate the region...it's a dream come true."

Political analyst Rekha Choudhary says that besides being showcased across India during the campaign season, the USBRL and other projects will be used to point out to the world that the abrogation of Article 370 had a socio-developmental purpose. "Besides boosting the economy," she says, "it will have a psychological impact on Kashmiris, as it will bring people closer with the rest of the country." ■

MAHA MESS IN CONGRESS

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

Maharashtra is witnessing serial earthquakes, politically speaking. As former chief minister Ashok Chavan took many by surprise on leaving the Congress for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) earlier this month, the latter was quick to project it as a third vertical split in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). In June 2022, Eknath Shinde had walked out on Uddhav Thackeray to topple the MVA government and take the reins of both the state and the Shiv Sena, and then in July 2023, Ajit Pawar split his uncle Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) to become a deputy chief minister—all this with the backing of the BJP.

For the Congress, this is the third high-profile exit within a month. The first was that of former Union minister Milind Deora on January 14, who will join Chavan in the Rajya Sabha as the Shinde-led Sena nominee. (The BJP declared Chavan as its Rajya Sabha nominee on February 14, just two days after he resigned from all Congress posts and as an MLA from Bhokar constituency.) Former state minister Baba Siddiqui is the other Congress deserter, who is now with the Ajit Pawar-led NCP.

Of these, Chavan is the real heavyweight and holds the capacity to count for more than one eventually. A senior BJP leader told INDIA TODAY that his move could open the floodgates for other Congress legislators. "This will be evident in the run-up to the Lok Sabha election," he claimed, "and during the assembly polls." The state's electorate will be voting for a new



REVOLVING CHAIR
Ashok Chavan at his office in Mumbai, Feb. 15

HINDUSTAN TIMES